

Module 02 — Your first real conversation

Claude Code 101 · Beginner Workshop · Module 2 of 8

A conversation is more than one prompt. By the end of this lesson you will ask, follow up, and decide what to keep.

What you'll learn

By the end of this 25-minute lesson you will be able to:

1. Run a multi-turn conversation in a single Claude Code session.
2. Ask a follow-up that refers to the previous reply.
3. Accept or reject a change Claude proposes.

Why this matters

- Most of the value of Claude Code comes from the second and third prompts, not the first. A single one-shot prompt rarely lands.
- Treating the session as a real conversation lets you correct course cheaply: "Shorter, please." "Use bullets." "Now the same thing in Python."
- Knowing how to **reject** a proposed change is just as important as knowing how to accept one. The whole tool relies on you being the final reviewer.

The one concept

Each prompt sees everything you said before — until you exit.

Inside one `claude` session, all your previous prompts and Claude's previous replies are visible to the model on every new turn. That's why a follow-up like "shorter" works without repeating the original question.

When you type `/exit`, the conversation ends and the next session starts fresh.

Show me

Three turns inside the same session. The user types after `>` ; Claude's replies are the indented blocks.

```
$ claude
> List three reasons a junior developer should learn Git.

1. Track changes over time without losing work.
2. Share code with a team through pull requests.
3. Recover from mistakes by rolling back to a previous commit.

> Shorter. One line each, no numbers.

Track changes safely.
Collaborate through pull requests.
Roll back mistakes easily.

> Turn that into a tweet.

Git is a junior dev's safety net: track changes, collaborate through pull requests, and roll back mistakes easily. #devtools

> /exit
```

Notice that the second and third prompts never repeat "Git" or "junior developer". The session remembered.

Try it yourself

Open Claude Code and run a 3-turn conversation about a topic you actually care about:

1. Ask any open question.
2. Reply with one of: `shorter`, `give me an example`, or `now explain it to a beginner`.
3. Reply with: `summarise that in one sentence`.

Save the whole transcript into `~/three-turns.txt`. The exercise README walks you through it.

Time budget: 8 minutes inside the session, 2 minutes to save the file.

Common mistakes

- **Exiting and reopening between turns.** Each `claude` invocation is a fresh session. Stay inside one session for the whole conversation.
- **Pasting an entirely new question that ignores the previous answer.** That's a new conversation, not a follow-up. If the topic changes, type `/exit` and start over.
- **Accepting a long answer because you feel rude saying "shorter".** Claude does not have feelings. Ask for what you want.
- **Forgetting to scroll up.** The early replies often have the cleanest version of the idea. Don't lose them when you copy.

Lesson reflection

Take 60 seconds:

1. Which follow-up gave you the most improvement: shorter, give me an example, or now explain it to a beginner?
2. Was any reply so far off that you would have rejected it on a real code change?
3. If you had to teach a colleague the "follow-up" idea in one sentence, what would you say?

What's next

Module 03 — **Asking for what you want** — teaches you to load up the first prompt so you need fewer follow-ups. You'll learn role prompts, constraints, and concrete output formats.

Budget for Module 03: 30 minutes.

Glossary card

- **Accept:** Choosing to keep a change Claude proposed.
- **Conversation:** A sequence of prompts and replies in the same Claude Code session.
- **Diff:** The set of lines Claude proposes to add and remove from a file.
- **Reject:** Choosing not to keep a change Claude proposed.